

Diversity Statement
Hema Shah
Economics PhD Candidate, Duke University

As a first-generation Indian American woman, I have seen firsthand the transformative power of education for economic mobility. Educational opportunity brought my family to America and allowed me to have a privileged upbringing. This privilege has enhanced my ability to succeed academically and has motivated me to center economic mobility and inequality of opportunity as the driving forces of my research agenda. This commitment is made clear in my scholarly work studying the impacts of unconditional cash transfers on low-income families with children as well as my work studying inequality in access to higher education.

While my privilege has aided my academic success, my identity as a woman of color has also posed challenges within the field of economics. As the only woman in my PhD cohort, I am conscious of the additional scrutiny my work may receive from students, peers, and professors. I have worked hard to project professionalism, demonstrate my work ethic and technical qualifications, gain my colleagues' respect, and make my voice heard.

My commitment to maintaining diversity and inclusion in the economics profession and paving the way for women of color in economics is also evident in my extracurricular pursuits. I have taken on several leadership roles in the economics department at Duke and used my influence to create an inclusive and welcoming culture. I served as a co-chair of the Economics Graduate Student Council for two years immediately following the COVID-19 pandemic. During my time as co-chair, I broadened our monthly department happy hours to include a full meal alongside beverages, which significantly increased attendance and made the events more welcoming and accessible to students from a variety of cultural and social backgrounds. Additionally, I directed a peer mentorship program that paired first year PhD students with upper year mentors, and I personally mentored several students with a particular focus on supporting women. To this end, I helped re-establish the Women in Economics group after it dissolved during the COVID-19 pandemic. Through this group, I organized social events that fostered connections between students and faculty, and I mentored women PhD students through student-organized coffee chats. My goal has been to serve as a trusted mentor and resource for women in the Duke economics PhD program.

Finally, I served as co-chair of the Duke Economics Graduate Mentorship Program, a student-run mentorship program for prospective economics PhD students from underrepresented backgrounds. This experience allowed me to connect with students from across the globe and contribute tangibly towards diversifying the economics profession. As a professor, I hope to further my contribution to diversifying the profession by mentoring students from underrepresented backgrounds and amplifying their voices in research that affects their communities.